THE POLL PLANKS



UNEMPLOYMENT AAP and Congress have promised up to a million government jobs in Gujarat. AAP has even promised 80 per cent reservation in private jobs for Gujarat domiciles



INFLATION: Both AAP and Congress are hoping to corner the BJP over price rise. The BJP counter includes two free LPG cylinders for Ujjwala scheme beneficiaries



FREEBIES: As AAP unleashed its free electricity, education and healthcare promises, PM Modi triggered a national debate on the freebie culture. But the BJP has also announced its own 'poll bonanza'. The Congress followed with a farm loan waiver



WATER: Gujarat is a water-deficient state, but the Narmada dam project has brought relief. The BJP repeatedly brings it up to target earlier Congress governments for not giving permission to raise the dam levels, and AAP as rights activist and big dam protester Medha Patkar was once associated with it. But recently, the BJP had to scrap the Par Tapi Narmada Link project, after the tribals protested fearing they would be displaced. The project had proposed to transfer water from the water-surplus regions of the Western Ghats to the water-deficit regions of Saurashtra and Kutch in Gujarat



GUJARATI ASMITA: The BJP seeks votes in the name of Gujarati pride which, in its narrative, means letting the Modi-led BJP have a smooth run in the state and at the Centre. Modi is the mascot of this narrative, which also puts the opposition parties on the back foot



HINDU NATIONALISM There has always been a projection of the Modi-led BJP as the protector of the Hindus. In fact, Gujarat saw the first experiment with this narrative. The recent release of Gujarat riot convicts is another extreme extension of this narrative. It is so strong that even AAP has steered clear of criticising the move

infighting among state leaders and absence of a charismatic state leader who can fill the void left by Modi. In 2017, the first election the BJP fought after Modi moved from Gujarat to become prime minister, the saffron party had got a scare—the Congress won 77 seats, the highest in over three decades. Most experts do predict victory for the BJP, but the PM will want nothing less than a win that puts an authoritative stamp on his popularity. In Gujarat, Modi has not hesitated to take tough action to remedy any situation that threatens to undo his legacy. In a snap overhaul in September 2021, the party installed a new chief minister—the third since 2014—and rejigged the entire cabinet.

As in the past, the BJP is banking on the agenda of development, led by Modi at the Centre and CM Bhupendrabhai Patel in the state, to carry the day. In the party narrative, this double-engine government is also important for Gujarati *asmita* (pride), as the engine of India's journey towards superpower status. A 10-day Gaurav Yatra (pride march) on five routes, covering 145 non-urban seats, concluded just before Diwali on October 24.

Added to that is another *asmita*, albeit misplaced—Hindutva pride. The horrific memories of the 2002 riots have been reignited by the Gujarat government's decision—approved by the Union home ministry—to release the 11 convicts in the case of Bilkis Bano, who was gangraped and saw 14 members of her family murdered. There is no mention of it in the electoral discourse, but analysts believe the BJP did it keeping in mind the Hindutva votes. The opposition AAP has steered clear of the issue. "We want to stay away from communal issues...this is a polarised electorate and we don't want to take sides," says an AAP source.

PM MODI HAS NOT HESITATED TO TAKE TOUGH ACTION IF A SITUATION THREATENS HIS LEGACY IN GUJARAT

Such assertions do not seem out of place. Congress turncoat C.K. Raulji, the controversial leader at the heart of the convicts' release, won from Godhra on a BJP ticket by a margin of just 258 votes last time. However, unlike in the past, the BJP campaign is not just about its accomplishments for Gujarat or the Hindus. If in 2017, the Congress set the agenda with its 'Vikas gone crazy' digital campaign, this time AAP has flooded the state with poll promises, leading Modi to denounce what he called the "*revadi* (freebies)" culture.

But then the PM visited Gujarat four times in October and announced a series of projects and government largesse such as two free LPG cylinders for Ujjwala scheme beneficiaries. The BJP has also come up with its own poll bonanza for voters—Rs 550 crore to revise the salary of lower-ranking policemen, a hike in the allowance of anganwadi and transport workers and *talati*s (revenue clerks), a hike in compensation for deceased servicemen from Gujarat along with plans to build a *shahid smarak* (memorial) on the Sabarmati riverfront, among others.

Farm distress is also a worry—it was a key reason invoked to explain the party's poor performance in 2017, particularly in Saurashtra. Earlier this